

1. **AI-Powered SOP and LOR Generator**

Users can input their academic and professional details, and the AI generates structured, grammatically accurate drafts tailored to their background and career goals.

This feature directly addresses Li Lei's primary need. As an international student unfamiliar with US application standards, he struggles to articulate his research achievements and career goals. The AI generates structured, grammatically correct drafts, tailored to his background, alleviating his writing burden and ensuring his application meets the expected format. This directly aligns with his user story of needing a tool to generate a well-structured SOP. It also helps Carlos, who struggles to connect his backend development experience to his AI aspirations. The AI can help him weave his technical skills into a compelling narrative for AI programs.

2. **SOP Refinement and Customization Tools**

Users can refine their SOPs within the system using AI-driven clarity, coherence, and tone adjustment features.

This feature benefits all three personas. Li Lei can use these tools to refine his SOP's clarity and coherence, ensuring it reads naturally and persuasively in English. This addresses his user story of wanting to refine his SOP within the system. Carlos can leverage the customization feature to tailor his SOP to each program's specific focus (research vs. industry), highlighting relevant skills and aligning with faculty interests, as described in his scenario. Astha, although unsure of her precise field, can use the customization tools to tailor her SOP once she selects programs, emphasizing transferable skills from her medical and nursing background.

3. **Graduate Program Recommendation System.**

Use AI to match users with relevant programs and provides insights into faculty research areas.

This feature is crucial for Astha. Facing a career crossroads, she needs help identifying relevant graduate programs. The AI analyzes her background, including her medical and nursing experience, and recommends programs in computer science and finance that align with her transferable skills and career

goals. This directly addresses her user story of wanting GradAid to help her identify relevant programs.

4. Structured LOR Template and Guidance

Assist applicants in generating structured Letter of Recommendation (LOR) templates to help professors write stronger, more personalized letters.

This feature assists Li Lei and indirectly supports all applicants. Li Lei, as a PhD applicant, needs strong LORs highlighting his research. The structured template guides his professors, ensuring they emphasize his key research experiences and align with his target programs, fulfilling his user story. While not explicitly mentioned in the scenarios for Astha and Carlos, structured LOR templates would also be beneficial for them in ensuring their recommenders can highlight the most relevant skills and experiences for their chosen fields.

Our team will avoid feature creep by staying focused on the defined personas, scenarios, and user stories. All new feature ideas will be evaluated against their direct benefit to Li Lei, Astha, and Carlos. We will ask "How does this feature specifically help one or more of these personas achieve their goals as outlined in their scenarios and user stories?" If the connection is weak or non-existent, the feature will be deprioritized or discarded. For example, a feature to help students find scholarships, while generally useful, doesn't directly address the core needs of our defined personas in their current scenarios.

We will also use user story mapping to visualize the user journey for each persona and identify the essential features needed to fulfill their core user stories. We will regularly review these maps and the user stories themselves to ensure we stay focused on the most critical functionalities. Any feature that deviates significantly from the defined user stories will be considered out of scope.